

Factors Affecting User Experience

Formative Activity

Review and respond to the [discussion in unit 5](#).

This task responds to the post by Tim Brayshaw (below)

Factors Affecting User Experience

User emotions play a big role in how people experience digital products, especially the first time they use them. First impressions are powerful, but they often do not reflect how users feel after spending more time with a product.

Gu, Tang and Xue (2023) explored this in their study of the halo effect, where users rate a product's usability more positively simply because it looks good. They found that this effect is strongest right after first use, but it fades within three days. I agree with their conclusion that this has big implications for user interface evaluation, waiting a few days before collecting feedback can lead to more accurate and realistic responses.

Psychological research backs this up. Clean layouts and limited information help reduce cognitive load, which makes users feel more at ease and in control (Mărcuță and MoldStud Research Team, 2024). When a design looks clean, modern and well organised, users often assume it will be easy to use, even if the underlying functionality has flaws. So early feedback often reflects how the interface looks and feels, rather than how well it actually works.

Visually appealing designs also tend to create positive emotions, which make users more forgiving early on (Thielsch and Hirschfeld, 2019). But there is a downside. When a product looks slick, users expect it to perform well. If it does not, those high expectations can quickly turn into disappointment (Bargas-Avila and Hornbæk, 2019).

That is why I think Gu et al.'s point is useful. Delaying evaluation gives users time to see past the surface and form opinions based on real interaction. Attractive design can cover up problems at first, but it also raises expectations. Letting users settle in before asking for feedback leads to better data and better decisions in user interface research.

References

Bargas-Avila, J.A. and Hornbæk, K. (2019) 'Old wine in new bottles or novel challenges? A critical analysis of empirical studies of user experience', *CHI Extended Abstracts*. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1145/1978942.1979336>

Gu, Q., Tang, W. and Xue, C. (2023) 'The effect of time lapse on the halo effect in the subjective evaluation of digital interfaces', in Marcus, A. and Rosenzweig, A. (eds) *Design, User Experience, and Usability: UX Research and Design*. Cham: Springer, pp. 171–183.

Mărcuță, C. and MoldStud Research Team (2024) 'The role of cognitive load in user interface design', *MoldStud*, 1 March. Available at: <https://moldstud.com/articles/p-the-role-of-cognitive-load-in-user-interface-design>

Thielsch, M.T. and Hirschfeld, G. (2019) 'Facets of website content', *Human–Computer Interaction*, 34(4), pp. 279–327. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1080/07370024.2017.1421954>

Factors Affecting User Experience: Response

Hi Tim

I was really interesting to read your post. I completely agree that 'Visually appealing designs also tend to create positive emotions.' I also completely agree that giving users time to review leads to better data. In my opinion, that's why the research by Gu et al is limited and even misleading. I'm not sure the 'Halo Effect' is valid and they may simply have stated the obvious my conducting flawed surveys. I believe this is because they ask users to comment about usability without sufficient knowledge. If people are asked to comment beyond their expertise, then they can only have the superficial to draw upon. Karen (2025) makes some interesting points regarding authority. While opinions can be valid without expert knowledge, there has to be a sufficient set of knowledge within a domain before an authoritative response can be formed. In my opinion Gu et al are confusing the subjective with the superficial and the halo effect is, in fact, just plain ignorance.

Keren, A. (2025). Expert Authority and Its Assessment. *Social Epistemology*, 1–14.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/02691728.2025.2472780>